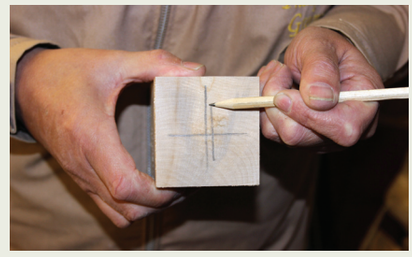
FINGER

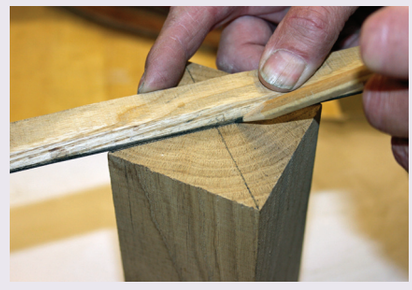
This is the method that can be used on both square and round timber and all you need is a pencil. On square section timber, hold the pencil in your fingers with the pencil protruding so the pencil tip is more or less on centre. Slide a finger along the timber side so you have a pencil line on the timber end. Rotate the timber 90° and repeat for the other three sides. It is important to make sure the distance of the pencil is the same on all four sides.

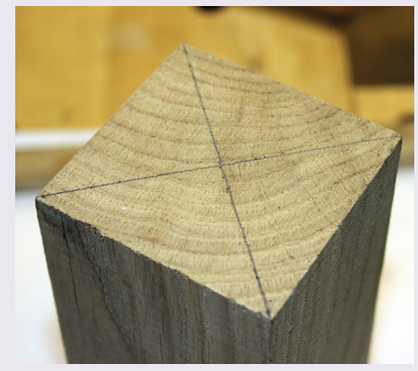
You should be able to see the centre. On round blanks, hold the pencil in the same way and draw an arc. Repeat this several times around the blank until you can see the approximate centre.



CORNER TO CORNER

This method is used on square timber using a ruler and a pencil drawing a line corner to corner and repeating on the other two corners. One main point to bear in mind is to offset the ruler by the thickness of the pencil point or where the two lines cross each other will not be in the middle, this is very easy to forget. The second photo shows this with the true centre being marked with the hole. If you're using a piece of timber to make a spindle with squares ends on, this offset would show up when mounted on the lathe, especially if turning a pommel or a bead which may have a flat on one side.

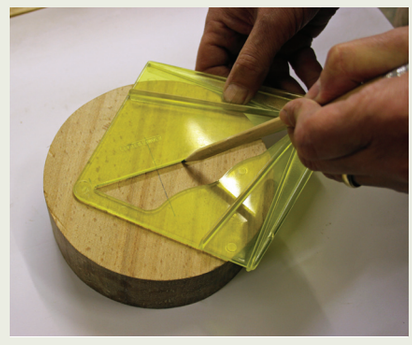


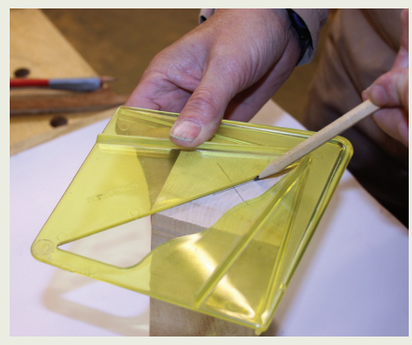


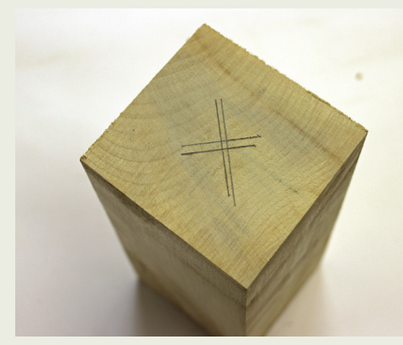
PLASTIC JIG

This is a plastic centre-finding jig and is very useful; these can be found in most turning supply shops and online. The jig can be used on both round and square timber. They are good for smaller round blanks but larger rounds call for different methods, which we will look at below.

For round section timber we place this on the blank and draw a line with a pencil then rotate the centre finder 90° and draw a second line. I normally draw at least two more lines, and then mark this with a bradawl where or as close to where all the lines intercept. If you are marking a very large blank use a ruler to extend the lines to the blank centre. For square section timber we use the jig on at least two corners, we then use a pencil to draw a line and then rotate to the next corner and draw a second line, repeat for the other two corners. Why bother with the two other corners? Well if the timber does not have 90° corners, the two lines may not join in the true centre.







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